

match — will be key to its fortunes and the difference between finishing in the top or bottom half of the competition.

Barring Hardik, the team is heavily reliant on its foreign stars in all areas: Lars Balk and Kane Russell in defence, the latter doubling up as a drag-flicker, Seve van Ass partnering Hardik in the middle, and Alvaro Iglesias and Tanguy Cosyns upfront.

There are also seasoned players like Lalit Upadhyay, along with Surender Kumar, Akashdeep Singh and Simranjeet Singh. Even though the last three are hoping to impress enough to get another shot at the national team, they lack the X-factor needed to inspire confidence.

Tamil Nadu Dragons

Men: This is another team heavy on overseas players, with Dutchman Jip Janssen being the standout one. Deadly with drag-flicks and possibly one of the few with a better conversion rate than Harmanpreet, the Paris Olympics gold medallist will be crucial to the Chennai side's hopes of advancing to the knockouts. Along with Amit Rohidas, the Dragons has a solid defence rivalled only by its attacking prowess.

The Australian trio of Blake Govers, Tom Craig, and Nathan Ephraums lead the forward line, with the Netherlands' Duco Telgenkamp joining in, and talented Indian youngsters Selvam Karthi and Bharan Sudev adding excitement on the field, making it a selection headache for coach Rein van Eijk. Expect them to score goals from all angles and hope Irish legend David Harte saves a lot at the back.

Hyderabad Toofans

Men: Hyderabad secured Gonzalo Peillat, and while it has other big names in its ranks, the team's fortunes will largely depend on the Argentine-turned-German, who continues to be a nightmare for teams with both his lethal drag-flicks and rock-solid defence. With the experienced Matthew Dawson in defence and Zachary Wallace and Maico Casella in midfield, the attack remains iffy.



Jean-Paul Danneberg, though low on experience, delivers high results and will man the post. However, Hyderabad's Indian roster remains its weakest link. The team is banking on little-known yet hardworking youngsters, hoping that the collective effort outweighs individual limitations.

Shrachi Rarh Bengal Tigers

Men: This is the one team that best personifies the thin line between confusion and combination, genius and cluelessness. It has roped in Australian Colin Batch as the chief coach, who, despite his astute understanding of hockey, was absent during the auctions and doesn't inspire much confidence given recent

Dominating presence: Deadly with the drag-flick and perhaps one of the few in the world with a better conversion record than Harmanpreet, Dutchman Jip Janssen will be the key for Tamil Nadu Dragons. GETTY IMAGES

results. The individual brilliance of some of the Aussies from their national side has managed to gloss over the obvious concerns, and that kind of reflects in the team that has been put together here.

On paper, it's a solid setup: Jugraj Singh, Hayden Beltz, Gauthier Boccard, and Tom Grambusch in defence; Lachlan Sharp and Sean Findlay in midfield; Abhishek Nain, Sukhjeet Singh, Florent Van Aubel, and Sam Lane leading the attack,